

**SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX**

DOMINIQUE THOMAS,

Plaintiff,

-against-

**THE CITY OF NEW YORK, OFFICER
YULENNY VERAS, SERGEANT EVAN
J. HODOS, OFFICER PADILLA,
OFFICER DURAN, OFFICER MOTA,
AND OFFICER NUNEZ**

Defendants.

Index No.:

SUMMONS

Plaintiff designates Bronx County as
the place of trial

To the above-named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorney(s) within twenty days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

The basis of venue is the location where the claims arose.

Dated: New York, New York
November 4, 2020

Rickner PLLC

By:



Rob Rickner

14 Wall Street, Suite 1603
New York, New York 10005
Phone: (212) 300-6506
Fax: (888) 390-5401

Attorney for Plaintiff

TO:

THE CITY OF NEW YORK
New York City law Department
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

INSERT

**SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX****DOMINIQUE THOMAS,**

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**THE CITY OF NEW YORK, OFFICER
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VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Plaintiff DOMINIQUE THOMAS, by her attorneys, Rickner PLLC, complaining of the Defendants, alleges, upon information and belief and personal knowledge:

NATURE OF THE CASE

1. This is a civil rights action brought against the City of New York and members of the New York City Police Department ("NYPD"), who violated Plaintiff's rights under the Constitution of the United States and the Constitution of the State of New York, and committed torts actionable under the common laws and statutes of the State and New York.

JURISDICTION

2. This action is brought pursuant to 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983 and 1988 for violations of Plaintiffs rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, Plaintiff's rights under Article 1, Section 12 of the Constitution of the State of New York, and the common laws of the State and New York.

3. An award of costs and attorneys' fees is authorized pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.
4. Pursuant to New York State General Municipal Law § 50-e, Plaintiff filed a timely Notice of Claim with the New York City Comptroller and the Comptroller designated the claim as number 2019PI029093.
5. Plaintiff appeared for a hearing under New York State General Municipal Law § 50-h on September 22, 2020.
6. Plaintiff's claims were not adjusted by the New York City Comptroller's Office within the period of time provided by statute.
7. Venue is properly laid in the Supreme Court of the State of New York, County of Bronx, because the Plaintiff's claims arose in the County of Bronx.
8. Plaintiff has been damaged in a sum which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction.

PARTIES

9. Plaintiff is, and was at all times relevant to this action, a resident of Bronx County in the State of New York.
10. Defendant the City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department that acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible.
11. Defendant the City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the NYPD.
12. Defendant police officer YULENNY VERAS (Shield No. 13483, Tax ID No. 966389) (hereinafter "Officer Veras") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD

officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein she was acting under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of her duties. She is sued in her individual capacity.

13. Officer Veras is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from her conduct described herein.

14. Officer Veras is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from her conduct described herein.

15. Defendant Sergeant EVAN J. HODOS (Shield No. Unknown, Tax ID No. 944081) (hereinafter "Sgt. Hodos") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein he was acting under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of his duties. He is sued in her individual capacity.

16. Sgt. Hodos is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

17. Sgt. Hodos is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

18. Defendant police officer PADILLA, whose first name is unknown, (Shield No. and Tax I.D. unknown) (hereinafter "Officer Padilla") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein he was acting under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of his duties. He is sued in her individual capacity.

19. Officer Padilla is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

20. Officer Padilla is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

21. Defendant police officer DURAN, whose first name is unknown, (Shield No. and Tax I.D. unknown) (hereinafter "Officer Duran") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein he was acting under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of his duties. He is sued in her individual capacity.

22. Officer Duran is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

23. Officer Duran is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

24. Defendant police officer Mota, whose first name is unknown, (Shield No. and Tax I.D. unknown) (hereinafter "Officer Mota") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein he was acting under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of his duties. He is sued in her individual capacity.

25. Officer Mota is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

26. Officer Mota is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

27. Defendant police officer Nunez, whose first name is unknown, (Shield No. and Tax I.D. unknown) (hereinafter "Officer Nunez") was at all relevant times described herein an NYPD officer, employed by the City of New York. At all relevant times described herein he was acting

under color of New York state law, and acting in the course and scope of his duties. He is sued in her individual capacity.

28. Officer Nunez is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York under New York law for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

29. Officer Nunez is entitled to indemnification by the City of New York pursuant to contract for any liability arising from his conduct described herein.

30. Collectively, Officers Veras, Padilla, Duran, Mota, Nunez, and Sgt. Veras are referred to as the "Individual Defendants."

31. At all times relevant herein, the Individual Defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of NYPD and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the NYPD at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the NYPD and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the NYPD.

32. At all relevant times, the Individual Defendants were engaged in a joint venture, assisting each other in performing the various actions described herein and lending their physical presence and support and the authority of their offices to one another.

THE VIOLATION OF PLAINTIFF'S CIVIL RIGHTS

33. On August 1, 2019, Plaintiff was lawfully within her residence at 1639 Fulton Avenue, Apartment B, Bronx, New York, 10452.

34. After calling 911 to request assistance for a domestic violence incident in which she was the victim, several NYPD units, including the Individual Defendants, arrived at Plaintiff's home.

35. Rather than respond to Plaintiff's concerns about the intoxicated man in her home who battered her, the Individual Defendants wrongfully detained and arrested Plaintiff without probable cause, while her attacker remained inside her home with her three minor children.

36. As a result of this wrongful arrest, Plaintiff was separated from her three minor children, who were detained by the Administration for Children's Services (ACS) for approximately 72 hours, despite Plaintiff repeatedly expressing that she had a family member who could care for the children during her detainment.

37. Plaintiff was then detained, booked, searched, and wrongfully held at the 42nd precinct.

THE INJURIES TO PLAINTIFF

38. This action seeks damages on behalf of Plaintiff for the extraordinary emotional pain and suffering, and loss of liberty that Plaintiff was forced to endure as a consequence of the Individual Defendants decidedly wrongful actions.

39. The Individual Defendants' actions were wanton, reckless, and malicious, as well as in blatant disregard of Plaintiff's civil rights, and as such the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages, as is the City of New York under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

40. All of the causes of action pleaded herein fall within one or more of the exceptions set forth in New York's Civil Practice Law & Rules 1602 with respect to joint and several liability.

**FIRST CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
FALSE ARREST UNDER 42 U.S.C. § 1983
AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS**

41. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

42. The Individual Defendants restrained and arrested Plaintiff without probable cause after she reported being the victim of domestic violence.

43. That by virtue of the aforementioned acts by the Individual Defendants, Plaintiff was deprived of civil rights guaranteed under the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution to be free from unreasonable or unlawful searches and seizures, and the Individual Defendants therefore are liable to Plaintiff for damages under 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

44. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

45. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

**SECOND CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
FAILURE TO INTERVENE AND CONSPIRACY UNDER 42 U.S.C. § 1983
AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS**

46. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

47. The Individual Defendants failed to intervene to prevent, end or report the unlawful and unconstitutional conduct to which Plaintiff was subjected despite the fact that they had opportunities to do so.

48. The Individual Defendants thereby displayed deliberate indifference to Plaintiffs rights, including Plaintiffs right to be free from unreasonable and unlawful searches and seizures.

49. The Individual Defendants also Defendants agreed among themselves and with other individuals to act in concert and thus conspired to deprive Plaintiff of clearly established civil rights.

50. That by virtue of the aforementioned acts by the Individual Defendants, Plaintiff was deprived of civil rights guaranteed under the Constitution of the United States, and the Individual Defendants therefore are liable to Plaintiff for damages under 42 USC § 1983.

51. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of her liberty.

52. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

**THIRD CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
ASSAULT AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS
AND THE CITY OF NEW YORK**

53. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

54. The Individual Defendants intentionally, willfully and maliciously assaulted Plaintiff in that they had the real or apparent ability to cause imminent harmful and/or offensive bodily contact and intentionally did a violent and/or menacing act which threatened such contact to the Plaintiff, and that such acts caused apprehension of such contact in the Plaintiff.

55. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

56. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

57. The City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

**FOURTH CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
BATTERY AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS
AND THE CITY OF NEW YORK**

58. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

59. The Individual Defendants intentionally, willfully and maliciously battered Plaintiff, when they, in a hostile and/or offensive manner struck Plaintiff and handcuffed him without his consent and with the intention of causing harmful and/or offensive bodily contact to the Plaintiff and caused such battery.

60. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

61. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

62. The City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

**FIFTH CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
FALSE ARREST AND FALSE IMPRISONMENT AGAINST
THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS AND THE CITY OF NEW YORK**

63. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

64. Plaintiff was arrested, handcuffed, and detained in the absence of probable cause by the Individual Defendants.

65. That at all times hereinafter mentioned, said arrest, confinement and restraint of liberty was not otherwise privileged.

66. Plaintiff was conscious of the confinement and did not consent to such confinement.

67. Plaintiff's arrest is *void ab initio* because Plaintiff was taken to a precinct or otherwise taken into custody, rather than being given a summons or other process without such detainment, in violation of New York Criminal Procedure Law § 150.20.

68. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

69. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

70. The City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

**SIXTH CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
INTENTIONAL AND NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS
AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS AND THE CITY OF NEW YORK**

71. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

72. The Individual Defendants engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, which intentionally and/or negligently caused severe emotional distress to Plaintiff.

73. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

74. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

75. The City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

**SEVENTH CLAIM FOR RELIEF:
VIOLATION OF ARTICLE I, § 12 OF THE NEW YORK STATE CONSTITUTION
AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL DEFENDANTS
AND THE CITY OF NEW YORK**

76. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

77. Such conduct breached the protections guaranteed to plaintiff by the New York State Constitution, including but not limited to, Article 1, §§ 1, 6, 8, 9, 11, and 12, and including the following rights:

- i. freedom from unreasonable search and seizure of her person and property;
- ii. freedom from arrest without probable cause;
- iii. freedom from false imprisonment, that being wrongfully detained without good faith, reasonable suspicion, or legal justification, and of which wrongful detention plaintiff was aware and did not consent;
- iv. freedom from the lodging of false charges against him by police officers and prosecutors, including on information and belief, by some or all of the individual defendants; and
- v. freedom from deprivation of liberty without due process of law.

78. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' deprivations of plaintiff's rights, privileges, and immunities guaranteed by the New York State Constitution, .

79. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

80. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the Individual Defendants are liable for punitive damages.

81. The City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff demands the following relief jointly and severally against all of the Individual Defendants, as well as the City of New York:

- a. Compensatory damages;
- b. Punitive damages;
- c. The convening and empaneling of a jury to consider the merits of the claims herein;
- d. Costs and interest and attorney's fees;
- e. Such other and further relief as this court may deem appropriate and equitable.

Dated: New York, New York
November 4, 2020

Rickner PLLC

By:


Rob Rickner

14 Wall Street, Suite 1603
New York, New York 10005
Phone: (212) 300-6506
Fax: (888) 390-5401
Attorney for Plaintiff

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

I, Rob Rickner, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirm the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

1) I am the attorney of record for the Plaintiff.

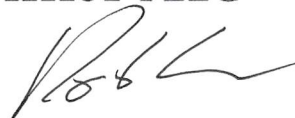
2) I have read the annexed Verified Complaint and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters, I believe them to be true. My beliefs, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, are based upon facts, records, other pertinent information contained in my files.

3) This verification is made by me because Plaintiff does not reside in the County where I maintain my offices.

Dated: New York, New York
November 4, 2020

Rickner PLLC

By:



Rob Rickner

14 Wall Street, Suite 1603
New York, New York 10005
Phone: (212) 300-6506
Fax: (888) 390-5401
Attorney for Plaintiff